3 | The Iran–Iraq War 1980–8

Key question
What were Saddam Hussein's motives for invading Iran?

In 1980 Saddam Hussein went to war with Iran. He had many motives for attacking his neighbour:

- There was evidence of Iran's involvement in the assassination of leading members of the governing Baathist party in Iraq.
- There was an ongoing dispute about the border in the south: Iraq's access to the sea was very narrow while Iran had a long coastline and several ports through which it could export its oil. Iraq wanted to gain complete control of the Shatt al-Arab waterway (see the map on page 122) and thus gain a secure outlet to the sea. Saddam might even be able, perhaps, to claim part of oil-rich, south-west Iran.
- Now seemed the ideal time to attack: Iran's economy was in chaos following the fall of the Shah's regime; the country was facing a Western boycott of its trade because of the capture of the US embassy; and the Iranian armed forces were demoralised.
- Above all, however, it was fear of Iranian plots to overthrow him that motivated Saddam Hussein. If he could take advantage of Iran's weakness and defeat his neighbour in a short, quick war, he could strengthen his regime and also become the leading power in the oil-rich Gulf.

Key date
Iran–Iraq War: 1980–8

The course of the war 1980–8

Key question
Why was the war so prolonged?

When the Iraqi army invaded Iran in September 1980 there was little resistance and most observers felt that a short war was likely. Saddam himself called it the 'whirlwind war', confident that a swift, heavy blow would dislodge Khomeini's government. The Iraqis advanced far into Iran but, within a month, had been brought to a halt in the Iranian desert. They now resorted to firing missiles at Iran's cities in order to terrorise the civilian population. So began the so-called 'war of the cities' in which both sides bombed and killed hundreds of thousands of civilians.

Within a year, the Iraqis had been forced back to their own border. They had superior firepower but Iran, with its much bigger population, sent in waves of new recruits, hundreds of thousands, many of them fired up with revolutionary enthusiasm and willing to become **martyrs** for the Islamic Revolution. A reporter on the Iranian front wrote:

> Religious slogans are posted everywhere, and sometimes reinforcements arrive cheerfully carrying their own coffins as a sign of willingness to be 'martyred'.

Key term
Martyr
Someone who dies or suffers greatly for a cause, especially for religious beliefs. There is a particularly strong tradition of martyrdom among Shiites.

A message, left by one young Iranian soldier for his parents, was typical:

> Don't cry mother, because I am happy. I am not dead. Dear father, don't cry because you will be proud when you realise I am a martyr.